

The Manus template — one paste, one finished episode

Fill the five brackets, paste the whole thing into a new Manus task. Written 15 Aug 2026 after the first four episodes, so every line in it exists because something went wrong without it.

Why each rule is there (do not trim these out — that is how they come back):

- **Wardrobe is spelled out and repeated.** The first Nia render came back with her near-undressed in all ten frames, because the reference image was a fashion photo and *a reference picture beats one word of wardrobe every time*.
- **"No text in the image"** — generators love to add captions of their own, and they arrive misspelled.
- **Nothing shown for substances.** TikTok and Meta remove content depicting drugs and a recovery framing is not an exemption. Absence is also the truer picture: what it looks like from the inside is rooms you stopped going into.
- **Ask for the recipe.** Manus is free until 25 Aug 2026. The commands it writes are the part worth keeping — they can be rebuilt into Studio later.
- **53 seconds** = ten shots at five plus a three-second end card.

THE TEMPLATE — copy everything in the block

Make one finished vertical video, and give me the recipe you used.

=== THE CHARACTER ===

[NAME]: [age, ethnicity, build, hair, distinguishing features].

Wearing [specific clothes]. Fully covered in every shot.

Keep this description word for word identical in every image prompt so the face does not drift. Never put the character's name inside an image prompt — describe them instead.

WARDROBE RULE FOR ALL IMAGES: everyday modest clothing, fully clothed, shoulders and chest covered. No swimwear, no lingerie, no bare midriff, no cleavage. This is a documentary-style film — dress them the way an ordinary person is actually dressed at home.

=== THE TEN SHOTS ===

One image per line, in this order, no merging and no reordering:

1. [shot description]
2. [shot description]
3. [shot description]
4. [shot description]
5. [shot description]
6. [shot description]
7. [shot description]
8. [shot description]
9. [shot description]
10. [shot description]

=== THE HOUSE LOOK — apply to all ten ===

cinematic photograph, shot on 35mm, shallow depth of field, warm practical light from lamps and screens only, muted color grade, documentary realism, vertical 9:16 composition, ordinary American apartment, no text in the image.

=== THE NARRATION, ONE LINE PER SHOT ===

1. [line]
2. [line]
3. [line]
4. [line]
5. [line]
6. [line]
7. [line]
8. [line]
9. [line]
10. [line]

Show these as on-screen captions, bottom third, verbatim – do not paraphrase, re-transcribe or "improve" them. The wording is exact.

=== THE MUSIC ===

Instrumental only, no vocals, 55 seconds: [music brief – instruments, tempo, mood]. Original composition, not based on any existing recording.

=== THE VIDEO ===

- 1080x1920, 9:16, 30fps, H.264 MP4
- Each shot holds 5 seconds. Hard cuts between shots, no crossfades.
- A slow Ken Burns move on every shot – alternate push in / pull out / drift.
- Music under the whole thing, ducked so the captions read.
- End on a 3-second card: "[END CARD BIG LINE]" with "[END CARD SMALL LINE]" beneath it. Same navy background as the images.
- Total runtime 53 seconds.

=== ALSO GIVE ME THE RECIPE ===

As well as the MP4, write a markdown file containing:

1. Each image prompt you sent, verbatim, numbered.
2. The full ffmpeg command lines you ran – including the zoompan/Ken Burns filters, the caption burn-in, and the audio mix. The actual commands, not a description.
3. The folder structure and every filename.
4. The music prompt and which tool generated the track.
5. Frame rate, resolution, codec, bitrate, audio settings.

Deliver: the 10 images, the music file, the MP4, and the recipe file.

Add this line when the episode involves substances or alcohol

Paste it directly under THE CHARACTER:

NOTHING IS SHOWN: no pills, powder, needles, paraphernalia, bottles, glasses of alcohol or any substance – not in a single frame, not blurred, not in the background. Every table and every hand is empty. This film is built on absence.

Filling it in — worked example, Episode 7

- **[NAME]** → DEE: white woman, late 40s, hair up in a clip, reading glasses pushed on her head, cardigan, tired kind face. Wearing a cardigan over a t-shirt and jeans. (A second character goes on the next line, same shape.)
- **The ten shots** → the SHOT lines from the episode in SERIES-2026-08-FOUR-EPISODES.md, without the backticks.

- **The narration** → the caption column of that episode's sequencer table.
- **The music brief** → that episode's Suno prompt.
- **The end card** → one of the four in `Studio/end-cards/`. Match it to the episode: *Keep going* for the ones told by the person who found out, *Face yourself* for the two spiritual ones, *Learn to love yourself again* for the ones told from inside.

After it delivers

1. **Watch it before anything else.** Check the wardrobe, check the captions word for word, and check no character's face drifted.
2. **Save the recipe file into this repo.** That is the part that outlives the free window.
3. **Log the music** in `MUSIC-LIBRARY.md` — prompt, file, date.
4. **Post through Studio**, not the tool, so the AI-disclosure flag is set and it lands in the Buffer queue.

TEMPLATE 2 — get the recipe back out

Paste this **into the task that already made the video**, not a new one. A new task has none of the files and will reverse-engineer from pixels, which means it will guess. The original task still has the prompts, the commands and the history.

Don't re-make anything. Document what you already did in this task, as a recipe I can run myself.

1. The exact image prompt you sent for each of the 10 shots, verbatim, numbered.
2. The exact ffmpeg command(s) you ran to assemble the video — full command lines, including the zoompan/Ken Burns filters, the subtitle burn-in, and the audio mix. Not a description; the actual commands.
3. The folder and file structure you used, and the filename of every asset.
4. The music prompt, and which tool generated the track.
5. Frame rate, resolution, codec, bitrate and audio settings on the final MP4.
6. Anything else needed to reproduce this exactly on another machine.

Write it as a single markdown file I can save. No video output needed.

Do this for every episode Manus makes, while it is free. Save the result in `reference/manus-recipes/`. The films are the output; the recipes are the asset.

It already paid for itself once: the recipes revealed that Manus's camera move is a **2% zoom over five seconds**, where Studio's default was 25%. That single number was most of the difference in how the two looked. See `reference/manus-recipes/README.md`.